

Herb and Joan are the picture of consistency, and their early retirement proves it. Herb grew up in a traditional middle-class family, and his father was intentional about teaching him how to work and save. As a boy, Herb sold bags of peanuts for a dime, and his dad showed him how to allocate part of his money to savings and part to spending. His dad often said, “Always give some money to your future. Don’t give it all to your present.” That simple lesson guided Herb’s finances his entire life.

Herb earned his business administration degree at The Citadel and then took a job at a large phone company. He stayed with that company for thirty years—which is something we don’t often see anymore. During that time, Herb and Joan had a goal of financial independence. They had a clear picture of what life would look like when they weren’t dependent on a full-time job for their income, and they talked about that goal often. To get there, they both maxed out their 401(k) plans and added in some other stock market investments. Herb said the 401(k) with his company’s matching dollars was the easiest way to hit his millionaire goal, even though it took a few decades to do it.

At age fifty-two, the couple was able to declare their financial independence in the best way possible. After thirty years with the phone company, Herb realized his job wasn’t fun anymore. That’s just a fact of life for most working Americans. Too many people get up every morning and drive to a job they hate because they can’t afford to lose the income. Not Herb. When he realized he wasn’t having any fun, he checked his investments, saw that he and Joan had plenty of money to live on for the rest of their lives, and left his job. He took early retirement at fifty-two—*because he could afford to*. He and Joan were millionaires by then, and millionaires get to make those kinds of decisions.

Looking back, the couple says their financial success comes down to four key factors. First, they said it took a commitment to a long-term goal. They knew from the start that it wouldn’t happen fast, but they knew it would happen eventually. Second, they said it required discipline. They had opportunities to derail their plan every day, and they needed discipline to stay on track. Third, they said their agreement as a couple was absolutely vital. We’ll talk more about that in a minute. Fourth, the couple knew from the outset that their plan would require patience. They knew it would take a while to get where they wanted to be, but today—retired in their fifties and with a net worth of \$2.9 million—they know it was worth it.

When we asked them why they thought most people fail to become millionaires, they didn’t hesitate. Herb said it comes down to a lack of planning and self-control, two things he learned in spades during his military training at The Citadel. “Trying to become a millionaire by playing the lottery is a stupid plan,” he said. “Investing may not be sexy, but it is the best way to grow wealth.”

Better Together

Herb and Joan’s story highlights something important that we don’t want to miss: their goal was to get to the millionaire finish line *together*. A broken marriage would have been a failure for them no matter what their